

The Thangaraj Stadium, nestled in a deep valley surrounded by the Nilgiri hills, is also the base camp for the Army's long-distance athletics team.

The Army runners, already doing their laps, glanced reverentially at Afsal as he began his warm-up.

"This is going to be an easy session," said Ajith, who was constantly exchanging pleasantries with Army coaches and athletes.

As Ajith looked on, Afsal began his laps at a jogging pace before upping the intensity, his bright green training vest soon blurring into a fluorescent streak among the greys, maroons and olives of the Army runners.

There is a consummate ease to Afsal's running. But a competitive 800m race isn't a graceful business, he admits.

Afsal remembers the first time he went

under 1:47 in the 800m. "My legs were fully cramped. I couldn't walk or stand properly."

"During a regular race, by 600m, lactic acid builds up in our body, our legs start getting tight, and our lungs feel like they're on fire. After an all-out race, I get severe headaches," says Afsal.

All these are forgiven, for the track is Afsal's one true devotion. If a world devoid of fatigue existed, he would probably be there, running forever.

But running wasn't always Afsal's fixation.

